The passive voice (present and past)

Goal: To form the passive voice in the present simple and the past simple, to change active sentences into passive ones, and to use the passive when the action matters more than the doer.

The idea in two lines: In the passive, the object of the active sentence becomes the subject, and the verb takes the form be + past participle. The doer (agent) is introduced by "by" or left out when it is unknown or unimportant.

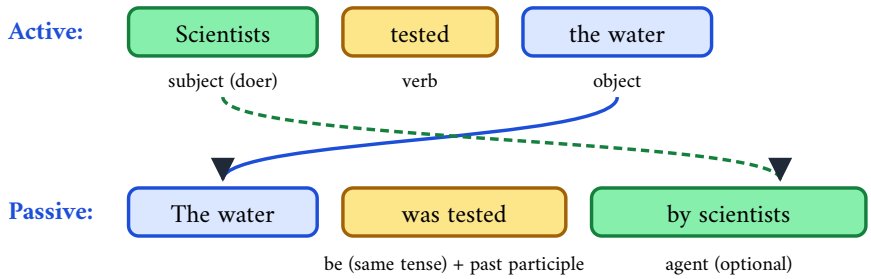


Figure 1: The object becomes the subject; the verb becomes be + past participle; the doer follows "by".

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** be + **past participle** (3rd column: tested, written, made). Only the verb "be" shows the tense.
2. **Present simple passive:** am / is / are + past participle. Samples are collected every morning.
3. **Past simple passive:** was / were + past participle. The results were published last year.
4. **Three steps to transform:** 1) the object becomes the subject; 2) put "be" in the tense of the active verb and add the past participle; 3) the old subject becomes the agent after "by" (or is dropped).
5. **Agreement:** "be" agrees with the new subject: The sample is analysed; the samples are analysed.

6. **When to use the passive:** the doer is unknown, obvious or unimportant, or we want to focus on the action or result, which is typical of scientific reports.
7. **Negatives and questions:** The data was not recorded. Was the test repeated?

🟢 Examples

1. Turn into the passive: The teacher corrects the papers every week. **Answer:** The papers are corrected every week (by the teacher). **Explanation:** present simple → are + corrected; plural subject → are.
2. Turn into the passive: Louis Pasteur developed the vaccine against rabies.
   Answer: The vaccine against rabies was developed by Louis Pasteur.
   Explanation: past simple → was + developed; the agent is important, so we keep "by Louis Pasteur".
3. Turn into the passive: Somebody stole my bicycle yesterday. **Answer:** My bicycle was stolen yesterday. **Explanation:** "somebody" is unknown, so the agent is left out.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Forgetting the verb "be": "The letter sent yesterday" instead of "The letter was sent yesterday".
- Using the past simple instead of the past participle: "was wrote", "is took".
- Wrong agreement: "The books was printed" instead of "were printed".
- Keeping "by people / by someone" when the agent should be dropped.

🟡 Quick review

- Passive = be + past participle.
- Present: is / are + p.p.; past: was / were + p.p.
- Object → subject; subject → by + agent (or omitted).
- "Be" agrees with the new subject.
- Use it when the action or result matters more than the doer.

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